Under Peer Pressure

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ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How does peer pressure online impact the decisions we make?

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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

1. Understand the meanings of **belonging** and **peer pressure**, and how they relate to each other.

2. Identify **peer pressures** online by analyzing scenarios.

3. Reflect on how to help others feel valued and included, both online and in person.

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

Have you ever felt pressure to download an app, play a game, or post something because "everyone else is doing it"?





It's natural to follow what friends and others are doing online because we want to feel a sense of **belonging**.

Belonging can create positive connections, but it can also lead to **peer pressure**, where someone feels influenced to act in ways they may not feel comfortable with.

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KEY VOCABULARY

Belonging

The feeling of being accepted, valued, and included within a group or community



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KEY VOCABULARY

Peer Pressure



The **influence** from others that pushes someone to adopt certain behaviors, attitudes, or values in order to fit in and gain acceptance.

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We're going to play a game of **bingo**. This bingo card shows different ways that peer pressure can show up online.

We're going to read four different stories about teens experiencing **peer pressure**, and mark our cards when we spot these behaviors.

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Step 1

Read through all of the squares in the bingo card.

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Bingo Bandwagon



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Freddie's Story

It was a Friday afternoon, and Freddie sat at his desk scrolling through Instagram. His last post was a photo he had spent an hour editing—and it hadn't gotten many likes. "Should I delete it?" he wondered, feeling self-conscious.

Instead, Freddie decided to repost an old photo that had been popular, hoping it would gain more traction. Later that evening, Freddie noticed his friends posting videos of a viral dance. "Should I?" he thought to himself. He spent an hour practicing, recording, and re-recording, and then spent ages editing the video.

He finally uploaded it and couldn't stop refreshing his notifications to see if anyone liked it. He also noticed a friend's post about their weekend plans. He quickly posted a picture of his dog, captioning it, "Weekend vibes." As the likes trickled in, he realized he didn't even have plans for the weekend.



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David's Story

Early in the morning, before school, David was sprawled out on his bed, watching his favorite gaming streamer, who had just announced a challenge: post a screenshot from your fastest speedrun and you'll be featured on stream.

David wasn't that into the game, but wondered if his friends were going to do the challenge. At school, David's friends were in a frenzy, talking about their submissions. "You haven't done it yet?" one of them asked. David laughed nervously and promised he'd submit something that night.

Later that evening, David scrolled online and saw his friend's latest post. The comment section was buzzing, so David liked it to show support—even though he wasn't particularly impressed.



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Carrie's Story

Carrie was up late at night tapping through stories when she saw a post about a social issue that was important to her. It seemed like everyone in her class was sharing it. She didn't fully understand the details but reposted it anyway, hoping that doing so might help her gain more followers and support. "Don't want people thinking I don't care," she thought.

The next morning, her group chat was filled with constant messages. Carrie felt overwhelmed and quickly read an article about the issue to get up to speed. When one classmate shared a surprising, questionable statistic, Carrie noticed it didn't match what she had just read earlier. Carrie typed out, "Are we sure that's accurate? I read something different." Carrie quickly deleted it and chose to remain silent in the chat.



Heather's Story

On the bus to school, Heather watched her favorite YouTuber's morning routine video, admiring her glowing skin, stylish fashion, and aura. "Why is her stuff so expensive?" Heather sighed. She opened her shopping app and added a few knockoff items to her cart.

During free period, Heather opened her Instagram to see beach vacation photos from her favorite YouTuber. "Why can't my family take trips like that?" she lamented. She scrolled through her phone's gallery, hoping to find something equally exciting to post.

Finding an old picture from a family picnic, she added a sunny filter and shared it to her main page and to her story. The story had a ton of views, but the post itself had very few likes, so she decided to hide the number of likes from public view.

After school, Heather told friends about her idea to make a GRWM video like her favorite YouTuber, but her friends mocked her—one even said, "You still watch her?" Heather felt embarrassed, and wanted to defend the videos, but didn't want to seem uncool in front of her friend, so she just laughed along.

We've seen how **peer pressure** online can sometimes push people to act in ways that might not be true to who they are.

Now let's think about the opposite—how we can create **a sense of belonging without pressure.**



Think about a time when you felt truly accepted online—when you could be yourself and still felt included.

What made you feel that way?



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Social media and online life can multiply peer pressure, both positive and negative.

Small actions like **showing support for someone being themselves** can create positive ripples that help others feel valued for who they are.

We can thrive in a digital world.

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